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*Shadows in the Light: Fathers, Sons, and Commentary on
the Fall of Russian Aristocracy, Failed Emancipation, and the Nihilist Forefathers of Revolution.*

Napoleon's disastrous invasion of Russia in 1812 signaled the beginning of the end for his empire. As the European powers rallied against the fallen emperor, Russia emerged as a decisive arbiter of power on the continent. The Second Treaty of Paris in November 1815 confirmed France's reduction to her 1789 borders and affirmed the ascendancy of the Russian Empire among Europe's great powers.

Over the ensuing decades, Russia began to slide from prestige into stagnation. While Western Europe surged ahead through industrialization and capitalist expansion, the Russian Empire remained a largely feudal and backward state. Mired in corruption, its bureaucracy struggled to exercise effective power or respond to the empire's growing need for reform. From this impasse emerged two rival schools of thought, each contending for intellectual and moral authority: the Westernizers and the Slavophiles.

The Westernizer, anxious at Europe's rapid industrial and military ascent, called for Russia's modernization, urging it to abandon the archaic peasant commune and feudal hierarchy in favor of a capitalist economy and a centralized state apparatus. The Slavophile, by contrast,

saw salvation in tradition. He urged Russia to embrace what made her distinct: to draw strength from the spiritual cohesion and communal life of her peasants.

Here the seeds of revolution were first sown. The Westernizer of the 1840s, seeking reform, placed his hopes in the autocracy itself—a faith that would prove decisive. The debate between Westernizer and Slavophile reached its reckoning in 1853, when a dispute over the rights of Christian minorities in Ottoman lands drew Russia into the Crimean War. Led by Tsar Nicholas I, the same ruler who had once stood triumphant over Napoleon and cast Russia as Europe's savior, the empire expected an easy victory. Yet when Britain and France came to the Ottomans' aid, their modern industry and weaponry crushed Russia's antiquated armies.

The defeat devastated the Slavophile's vision of divine and communal strength. Russia's failure to modernize had finally exacted its price. The Westernizer's call for reform now carried the weight of prophecy. Nicholas I would not live to see the war's end; his son, Tsar Alexander II, ascended the throne amid the shock of Russia's humiliation.

In an attempt to retain power in a nation torn between the demands for modernization and the deepening marginalization of the serf class, Tsar Alexander II made a decisive move. He would roll out a vast reform—intended to strengthen the military, revive the economy, and restore Russia's imperial prestige. That decision was the 1861 Emancipation of the Serfs. In his own words: “It is better to abolish serfdom from above than to wait for it to abolish itself from below.” Emancipation promised economic modernization, military resurgence, and moral reparations. It failed spectacularly, becoming a half-measure that left the peasantry burdened with redemption payments and disillusioned many radicals, such as Nikolay Chernyshevsky, who had hoped for more sweeping transformation.

It is here, after two Tsars, half a century, and two pages of context, that we arrive at *Fathers and Sons* by Ivan Turgenev. Widely deemed his most prominent work, this novel keeps a masterful pulse on its times. *Fathers and Sons*, born out of the changing tumult of the 1860s, details a story about power. Though this power inspired revolutionary change attempted through the Nihilists, it merely shifted hands—from the weakened aristocracy into a newer generation.

In short, the book is about the power-struggle in Russia during the 1860s. The aristocracy is dealt a fatal blow via the 1861 emancipation of the serfs, and its fading power is represented in two men: Pavel Petrovich and Nikolai Petrovich. A newer, nihilist generation is embodied in Yevgeny Bazarov and the young Arkady Nikolaievich. Around the axis of power, ideas of authority and liberty shift from father to son. It is on this axis that the novel revolves.

To grasp how power shifts, one must first examine with whom it rests initially. Though the massive 1861 Emancipation reform loomed on the horizon, in the world of *Fathers and Sons* this reform remains unrealized — the novel unfolds just before it takes effect, at a moment of rising tension between aristocracy and serfdom. Therefore, at the beginning of the novel, power still firmly resides in the aristocracy, embodied in figures like the Petrovich (Kirsanov) brothers.

As the book begins, we see that the brothers are different in many ways but united by blood. Pavel is described as “a man of medium height, dressed in a dark English suit... his closely cropped gray hair shone with a dark luster, like new silver; his face... unusually regular and pure of line... his bright, black almond-shaped eyes were particularly exquisite... the entire figure... elegant and well-bred, retaining a youthful gracefulness...”(Turgenev pg. 8) . He is powerful in image—a façade that will later crumble. From the start, Turgenev makes clear that Pavel’s authority is largely symbolic: a form of aristocratic power rooted in appearance, ritual, and cultivated social presence, and one that depends on being seen rather than exercised.

Even before we meet Pavel, however, we encounter a very different kind of aristocrat in his brother, Nikolai Petrovich. He is depicted as humble and lacking confidence: he “sat down on the bench... feet tucked under him... gazing thoughtfully around”(Turgenev pg. 1) . This introduction establishes Nikolai as passive and anxious, hardly authoritative. Unlike Pavel’s controlled elegance, Nikolai appears mild, even timid. His demeanor immediately signals a weakened paternal authority and, more broadly, hints at the decline of the aristocracy as a whole.

Nikolai fails to command. He “was undistinguished by bravery” and even “earned a reputation as something of a coward” (Turgenev pg. 2). Born into privilege as the son of a general, he grows into a man who never expands his influence beyond the shadow of his father. This is visible in his behavior around Arkady: he “seemed much more excited than his son... he seemed... flustered, grown timid as it were” (Turgenev pg. 3). Power is already shifting; we witness the early reversal of generational authority, as Arkady appears more self-possessed than the man meant to guide him.

Nikolai represents the man of the 1840s: he acts throughout the novel, yet his actions feel aimless, for he lacks the knowledge or decisiveness to enact meaningful change. Pavel represents the flipside of that same decline: he possesses worldly experience, cultivated taste, and firm “principles,” yet no deeds to his name, leaving behind a legacy of empty words. His authority is one of posture rather than accomplishment. Despite his hollow authority, he believes deeply in his superiority, especially over those of lower birth: “Pavel Petrovich bowed his elegant figure slightly and smiled slightly but didn’t extend his hand and even put it back into his pocket” (Turgenev pg. 9).

This fragility is further expressed in Pavel’s obsession with principle: “We’re people of another age... without principles, accepted on faith, it’s impossible to take a step, to draw a

breath” (Turgenev pg. 13). These words reveal Pavel’s belief in moral-authoritative power, his generational rigidity, and the ideological foundation of his aristocratic worldview—precisely the framework Bazarov rejects. Pavel Petrovich is a man built around the shell of aristocracy, and thus any crack in that idea threatens to collapse him entirely: “This time proved more difficult for Pavel Petrovich than for anyone else: when he’d lost his past, he’d lost everything” (Turgenev pg. 19). Aristocracy constitutes the core of the Kirsanovs’ authority, which is why Pavel is so deeply unsettled by the novel’s protagonist, Evgeny Vasilich: “His aristocratic nature was disturbed by Bazarov’s free-and-easy manner... in the sound of his voice, there was something rude, almost insolent” (Turgenev pg. 15).

And hollow his power is. The reader quickly learns that Nikolai manages the Kirsanov estate—and manages it poorly: “I’ve had a lot of trouble with the peasants this year... they don’t pay their quitrent” (Turgenev pg. 5). Nikolai possesses formal authority as a landowner but not functional power; even serfs disregard him. The symbolic collapse of aristocratic order, even before emancipation arrives, is unmistakable. Furthermore, Nikolai is barely solvent: “I needed the money; besides, that land’s to be given to the peasants” (Turgenev pg. 6). Ultimately, the novel begins with power only tenuously in the hands of the aristocrats. In the broader historical context, this reflects the real trajectory of Russia in the late 1850s: the eve of a profound shift in power, one that appeared poised to change the social order entirely.

Let us discuss this change. If the Petrovich brothers are representative of the aristocracy, then Bazarov represents the pure driving force of the power shift: the nihilist movement. “Yes, and am I supposed to pander to them, these provincial aristocrats? Why, it’s all vanity, society habits, foppishness” (Turgenev pg. 16). The very beliefs on which the upper classes balance are not acknowledged by Bazarov or his nihilist movement. The only thing Bazarov accepts is

empirical certainty: “Two times two makes four; all the rest’s nonsense” (Turgenev pg. 26). We see this influence reflected in Arkady, the heir to the Kirsanov estate: “Suddenly Arkady comes up to me and silently, with an expression of such tender compassion, very gently, as if I were a little child, takes my book away and places another one in front of me, a German one... he smiles and then leaves, carrying away my Pushkin” (Turgenev pg. 28).

As the times change, the romantic ideas of the 1840s are washed away by the tides of nihilism. The effect is undeniable. Yet the futility of nihilist thought also reveals itself here. Change manifests itself in Bazarov, but he is a special case. It fails to penetrate the youth of the upper class. For power to shift truly, and for change to take hold, nihilism would have had to replace the ideology of the past entirely. We see the roots of nihilism in Bazarov’s background: “Bazarov is the son of a poor district doctor... his life was poor, laborious, and difficult” (Pisarev pg. 3). Pisarev, one of the leading nihilist voices of the 1860s, acknowledged that it takes an austere life for a man to scorn art and dedicate himself to a materialist worldview.

Furthermore, Bazarov is inherently motivated to cut down the institutions that oppress people of his status: “He supported himself at the university by his own labor, eking out a living by giving cheap lessons... Bazarov emerged from this school of labor and deprivation a strong and stern man” (Pisarev pg. 3). For such a man, the aristocratic worldview is impossible to embrace. Anyone who must work today to eat today, and pay yesterday’s debts, has no room—or luxury—to dream about tomorrow.

Pisarev explains why Turgenev scripts nihilism to fail: it simply fails to capture the hearts of most people. Bazarov never bothers trying to explain his worldview: “The disease of an age first infects the people who by virtue of their mental powers stand higher... Bazarov... is distinguished by his remarkable mind and consequently produces a strong impression... He

looks down on people and rarely even takes the trouble to conceal his half disdainful, half-patronizing attitude toward those who hate him and those who obey him. He loves no one..." (Pisarev pg. 5). Bazarov becomes, in Pisarev's reading, a revolutionary of the future born too early. He is far more intelligent than his contemporaries, standing a head above the rest. Why would he bother explaining his beliefs to people who could never appreciate them? In Bazarov's own words to Arkady: "Yes... you're still a fool."

Pisarev ultimately shows why nihilism could never take hold: the aristocrats were too entangled in their soft lives to acknowledge its demands, and the peasantry too distant from materialist philosophy to accept it. Thus, the movement was born into—and died within—the ranks of the intelligentsia, much like Evgeny Bazarov himself.

So the aristocracy is teetering at the edge of oblivion, and nihilist thought seemingly carries enough force to push it over, changing all of Russia and shifting power finally into the hands of the people. Yet it stops short. Why? According to Turgenev, the answer lies in Arkady Nikolaevich. As mentioned before, the aristocratic youth—represented by Arkady—never experienced the struggle or deprivation that turned so many poorer men into nihilists. As a result, he never truly abandons the ideology he was born into: "I'm no longer the haughty little boy I was when I came here... I'm no longer searching for ideals where I did previously; they're appearing to me much closer at hand" (Turgenev pg. 113).

Turgenev uses this chasm to demonstrate nihilism's inability to take hold of the future. Bazarov, unwavering and unyielding in his convictions, cannot adapt or cooperate with those unlike himself. He alienates the aristocracy in his rivalry with Pavel and fails to inspire genuine ideological transformation in Arkady. With Bazarov's death, Turgenev seals the fate of nihilism

within the novel: a movement that arrived with the potential to enlighten the world, burned too fiercely for its own good, and disappeared as abruptly as it emerged.

Arkady, though throughout the novel is seen as subordinate to Bazarov, undergoes a change midway throughout the novel. Both young men, though strong of mind, experienced a deep weakness of heart. As often goes, the inflection point of their lives was a woman: “He was breathing hard; his whole body was trembling visibly... it was passion struggling within him—powerful and painful—passion that resembled malice and was perhaps even related to it” (Turgenev pg. 65). Bazarov, a man untamed by emotion, is forcefully brought to kneel by his newfound obsession with Anna Sergeevna. Joining him in this potent lovesickness is his protégé: “Their faces had changed since last we saw them: Arkady appeared calmer, Katya livelier and bolder... each one seemed not to be thinking about the other, while secretly rejoicing in the other's proximity” (Turgenev pg. 105).

These two quotes reveal a deep contrast between the fortunes of the aristocrat and the nihilist. Bazarov is overcome with a deep desire, and yet he fails to manifest a meaningful relationship of it: “You’ve misunderstood me,” she whispered in hurried alarm. It seemed that if he took another step, she’d scream... Bazarov bit his lips and left the room” (Turgenev pg. 65). We see here Turgenev predicting the reason why nihilist thought fails to transition power. Though Bazarov allows his humanity to emerge in his love, his destructive nihilism leads only to his jilted undoing at the hands of his heart. Arkady, on the other hand, marries Katya, who reciprocates his feelings.

These passages echo the thoughts of another thinker, Kristian Petrov: “Although nihilists fought for autonomy, revolution and a new society, the movement was ironically stuck in a continuous negation of its inspirers and forerunners” (Petrov pg. 1). Bazarov purposefully

isolates himself, from the older generation as seen in his feud with Pavel, and from the younger aristocrats, as seen in his condescension with Arkady. Thus, he has no support structure to carry him from his emotional humiliation at the Odintsova estate. The real-life representation of this idea is evident in Petrov's beliefs: "The act of absolute negation... ultimately implies self-negation, taking... the form of personal misery, failure, madness or death" (Petrov pg. 2).

Thus, we see that nihilism was not self-sustaining, but rather, in a twist of cruel irony, dependent upon the very structures it sought to tear down. Bazarov doesn't just fail emotionally, but is somehow sucked back into an archaic, postured tradition – something that represents the antithesis of his own beliefs: "Damn it all! So elegant and so stupid! What a farce we've just acted! That's how trained dogs dance on their hind legs" (Turgenev pg. 97). Despite nihilism claiming to snatch power from the pre-existing institutions it refuses to acknowledge, its literary manifestation in Bazarov is reminded that it is utterly dependent upon generational conflict. Petrov remarks something similar: "Russian nihilism was situated within an intergenerational cultural conflict which permeated Russian literature and society during the 1860s" (Petrov pg. 2).

Much like a vacuum chamber, Nihilism could destroy everything – only in a closed system. But just as the vacuum needs the chamber to prevent the outer atmosphere from crashing in upon itself, the nihilist needed the chasm between father and son to find his niche; It simply was not sustainable for the social vacuum that was the nihilist to hold onto influence and power without putting anything back into the world. Likely, this is why Turgenev writes the duel into the novel. Though it is so against the materialist, anti-traditionalist ideology that Bazarov ascribes to, it is arguably the strongest, most thought-provoking representation of the generational conflict that existed in the 1860's.

The duel itself is deeply uncomfortable, tense acknowledgement between two vastly different men: “No one in sight, no one to interfere ... Shall we begin?” (Turgenev pg. 98). It’s a ritual, with Pavel’s private setup being a call back to an older code of honor – the very code Bazarov rejects. He tries his best to belittle this situation, but regardless of whatever he claims, he still goes through this self-proclaimed “farce”: “You seek to make light of everything,” replied Pavel Petrovich. “I don’t deny the strange nature of our duel, but I consider it my duty to warn you that I intend to fight seriously.” ... “We can begin” (Turgenev pg. 98). Turgenev writes Pavel, the old guard, as barely able to contain his contempt for the nihilist. And yet, the courteous posturing that this Kirsanov displays is yet more unsettling. Bazarov, though calm on the surface, is clearly shaken from the gravity of this duel. “Something whizzed sharply past Bazarov’s ear, and, at the same moment a shot rang out... Pavel Petrovich shuddered slightly and grabbed his thigh. ... Bazarov tossed his pistol away and approached his opponent. ‘Are you wounded?’ he asked. ... ‘Now I’m no longer a duelist, but a doctor” (Turgenev pg. 99).

The duel ends with little in the way of closure: “Each was aware that the other understood him. Friends find that experience pleasant, but for enemies, it’s extremely unpleasant, especially when they find it impossible either to reach any understanding or to go their separate ways” (Turgenev pg. 100). Petrov explains this idea: “Many of the prominent šestidesjatniki were of noble birth ... the two generations became increasingly confrontational towards each other” (Petrov pg. 9). We see that though both men believe in their own superiority, neither is able to confirm it, instead deferring to the other’s strengths. Bazarov is unable to free himself from the chains of tradition, and Pavel ultimately succumbs to Bazarov’s youth and vitality, emerging worse for wear in the duel, surviving only due to Bazarov’s treatment: “Nihilism... was situated

within an intergenerational cultural conflict... the younger nihilists emerged dialectically within the relation to their predecessors and inspirers” (Petrov pg. 8).